

70 Telling things to people

You can use both “say” and “tell” in reported speech. The meaning is the same, but using “tell” allows you to specify who someone was talking to.

-  **New language** Reported speech with “tell”
-  **Vocabulary** Collocations with “say” and “tell”
-  **New skill** Talking about truth and lies

70.1 KEY LANGUAGE “SAY” AND “TELL” IN REPORTED SPEECH

In reported speech, you can say who someone is talking to when you use “tell” as the main verb. “Tell” must be followed by an object.

I want to learn to drive.



He { **said** / **told me** } that he wanted to learn to drive.

With “say,” you do not need an object to show who someone is talking to.

In reported speech, you must put an object after “tell” to show who someone is talking to.



70.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES “SAY” AND “TELL” IN REPORTED SPEECH



She **said** that she could come to the party.



She **told me** that she had a very stressful job.



He **said** he would be late to the meeting.

You can leave out “that” in reported speech with “said.”



They **told us** they were buying a new house.

You can also leave out “that” in reported speech with “told.”



70.3 ⚠ COMMON MISTAKES “SAY” AND “TELL” IN REPORTED SPEECH

He **said** that he had a fast car. ✓

He **said me** that he had a fast car. ✗

“Said” cannot have an object.

He **told me** that he had a fast car. ✓

He **told** that he had a fast car. ✗

“Told” must have an object.

